SimplArchive

User Manual

An enterprise-grade document management system
— the web workbench and the desktop client

Hebel Consulting GmbH
Schweighofplatz 7
6010 Kriens (LU)
Switzerland
support@simplarchive.dev

Contents

1 Introduction

SimplArchive is a multi-tenant **document management system** (DMS): a secure archive where an organisation files, versions, classifies, searches, and governs its documents. It is a showcase of how a senior, AI-driven software developer can produce a complex, enterprise-grade system in a relatively short period — every feature in this manual is really implemented and really tested.

You reach the same archive through **two clients**, which mirror each other feature for feature:

- the **web workbench** — a browser application, nothing to install;
- the **desktop client** — a native Windows / macOS / Linux application that can additionally open a document in its real desktop program and drag documents in and out of the operating-system file manager.

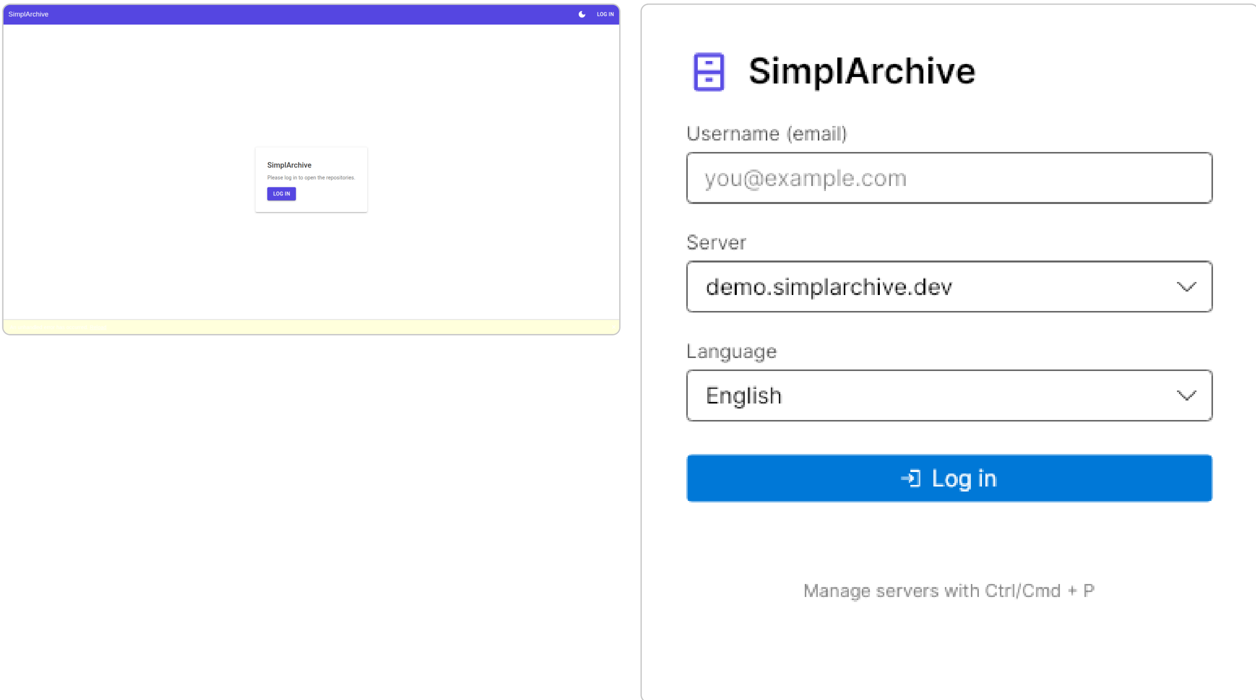

Figure 1: The two clients: the web sign-in (left) and the desktop logon window (right).

1.1 Core concepts

Repository — a top-level archive; it is simply a folder with no parent. **Folder** / **document** — the tree inside a repository. **Version** — every change to a document's file is kept as a new version; nothing is overwritten. **Mask (document type)** — a template of **index fields** (metadata) attached to a document. **ACL** — a per-document access-control list of **rights** (see, read, edit, …) granted to users and groups.

2 Getting started

Signing in. Open the web client and choose **Log in**, or start the desktop client and use its logon window; enter your e-mail and password. Your organisation may additionally require a second factor (a one-time code or a passkey). You can pick the interface **language** (English, German, Italian, Spanish) and switch between a **light** and **dark** appearance at any time.

The workbench. After signing in you land on the **Repositories** workbench, laid out as: the **tree** of repositories and folders, the **contents** list of the selected folder, the **detail** pane (index data) over the **preview**, and — along the bottom — the **tab bar** that switches between Repositories, Inbox, Search, Tasks and the rest.

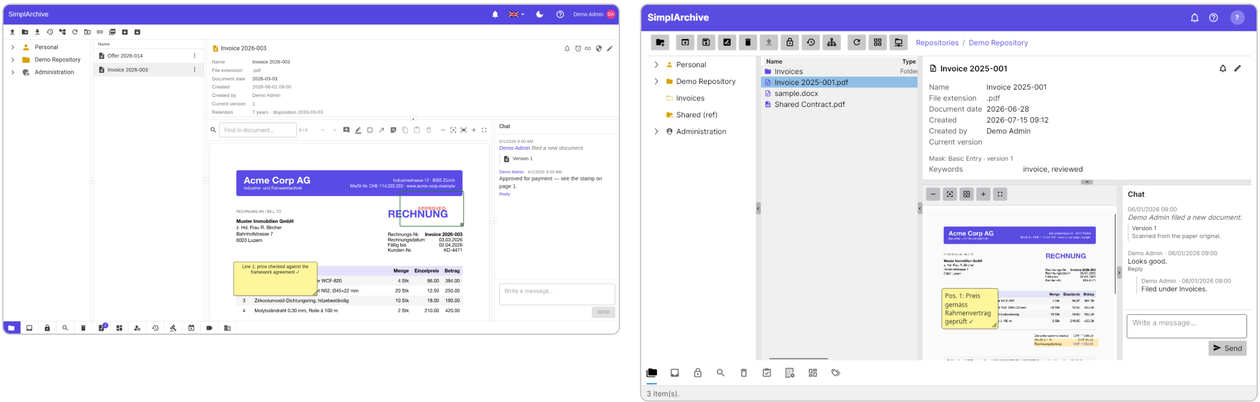

Figure 2: The workbench in the web client (left) and the desktop client (right): tree · contents · detail · preview, with the bottom tab bar.

3 Browsing & previewing documents

Expand the **tree** to a folder and its documents appear in the **contents** list, which you can sort by any column. Selecting a document shows its **index data** in the detail pane and renders a **preview** below — PDFs, images, and converted Office/e-mail/Markdown documents alike. Full-text search hits are highlighted directly on the preview, and you can click a word to copy it. In the desktop client you can also **open** the document in its native application — from the row's context menu, the ribbon, a double-click, or the keyboard shortcut **⌘O** (**Ctrl+O** on Windows and Linux). The same shortcut opens the selected item on the **Inbox** tab.

The preview's toolbar carries the **zoom** controls. A document opens fitted to the width of the pane; *fit page* shrinks it until the whole page is visible at once — useful when the pane is wider than it is tall, where fitting the width pushes the bottom of the page out of sight. Zooming out after that walks back down to the whole page and stops there. Ctrl+scroll (⌘+scroll on a Mac) zooms as well.

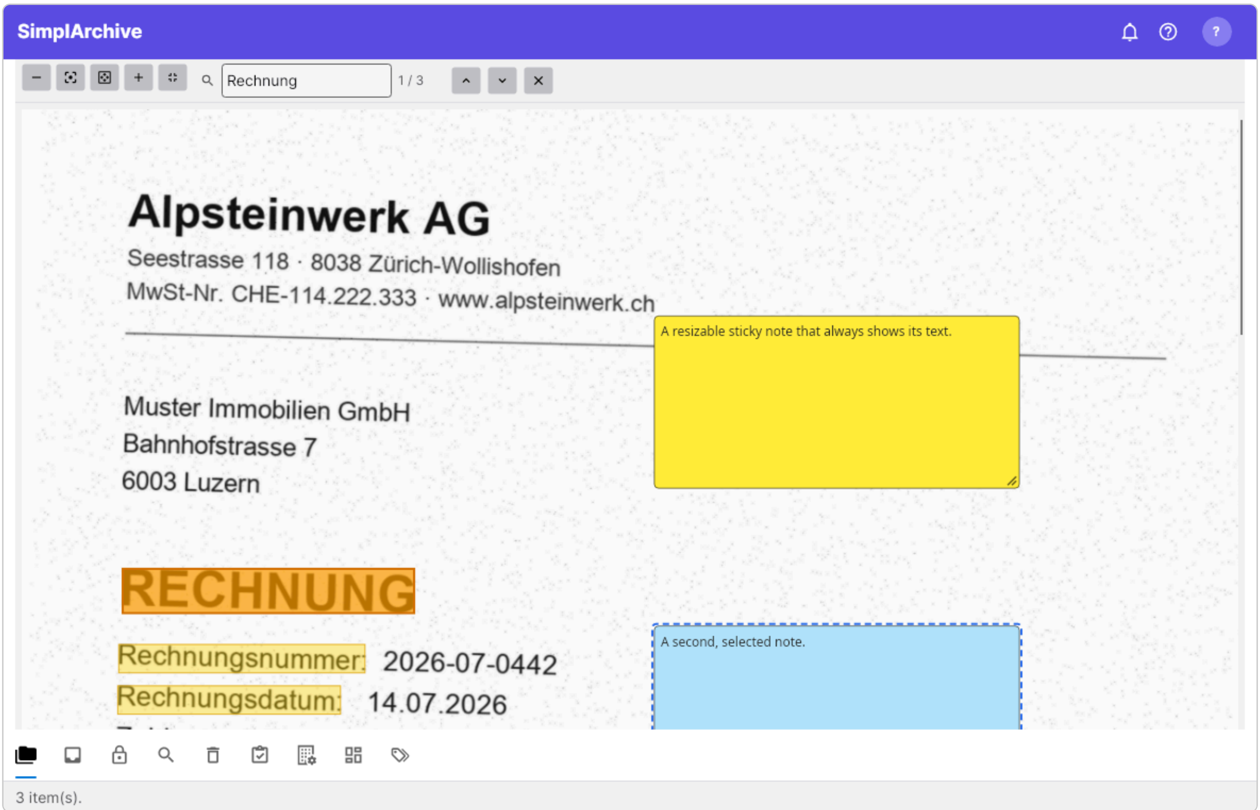

Figure 3: The preview with search hits highlighted on the page — click a word to copy it, or step through the matches.

4 Adding & versioning documents

4.1 How documents get in

There is more than one way in, and which you want depends on whether the document is finished, whether it belongs to something already filed, and how many you have. They all end in the same place.

Route	Use it when
Upload on the ribbon	You are already looking at the folder it belongs in. Picks files and files them straight into the open folder.
Drag onto a folder — a row in the list, or a node in the tree	You can see the destination. The document is filed there; the view follows to that folder so you can see it arrive.
Drag onto empty space in the contents list	Same as above for the folder you are already in.
Drag onto a document	The file is a newer copy of that document — it is added as a **version**, not as a second document, and the history is kept.
Drag onto Personal ▸ Inbox	It is not ready to file, or you do not yet know where it belongs. It waits in the Inbox until you classify and file it.
Drag a document onto Personal ▸ Inbox	You want to start from an existing document as a **template**. A copy lands in your Inbox carrying that document's document type and index data, so you edit what differs. Nothing is created in the archive until you file it.
Drag onto Personal ▸ Check-out	You checked a document out, edited it on your computer, and are bringing it back. The file must still carry the document's name — that is what says which document it belongs to.
WebDAV	You would rather work in Finder, Explorer or Files. Mount the archive as a drive and copy documents in like any other folder.
Import	You are bringing in a whole folder tree at once, exported from SimplArchive or elsewhere.
Email attachment	You filed an email and want one of its attachments as a document of its own.

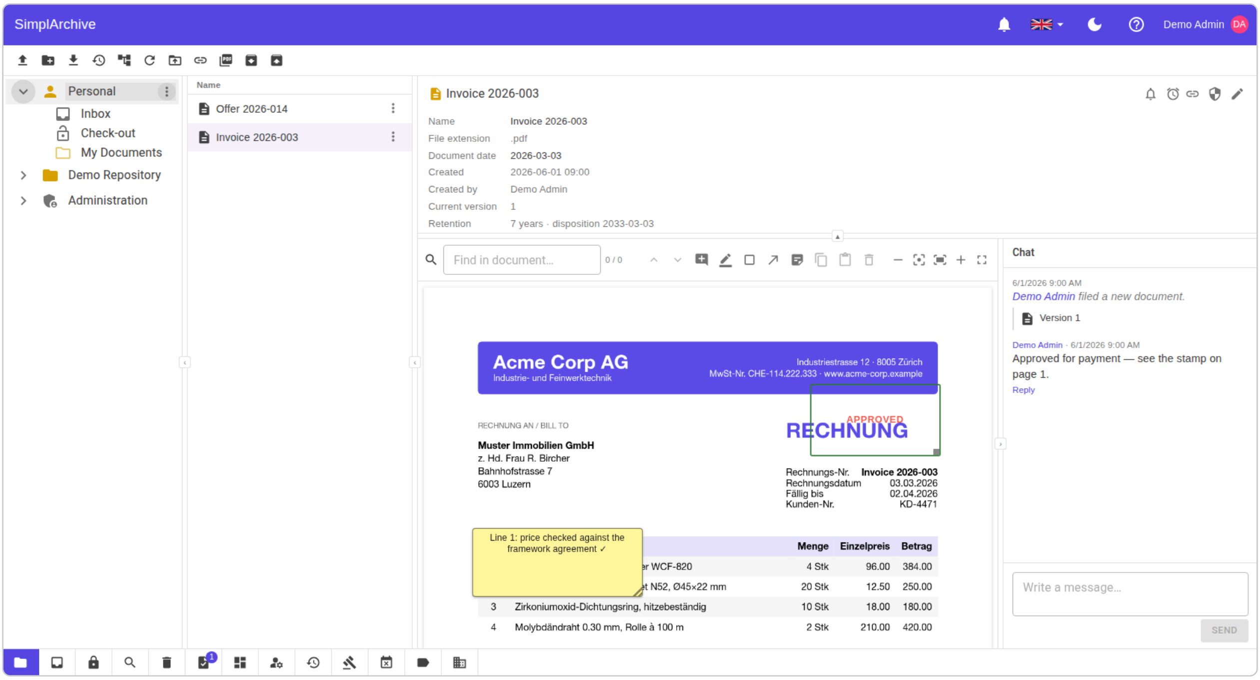

Figure 4: The **Personal** space expanded: **Inbox** and **Check-out** sit above your own folders. Drop files on **Inbox** to stage them, or drop an edited working copy on **Check-out** to bring it back — and drag a document onto **Inbox** to start new work from it as a template.

> **Two of these do not create a document.** A drop onto the **Inbox** stages an item — it becomes a document only when you file it. A drop onto **Check-out** replaces your working copy — the document gets a new version only when you check it in. Everything else files immediately.

Uploading. Drag a file straight onto a folder (the bytes go directly to object storage — the server never proxies them). **The Inbox** is a staging area: drop scans or files there, then classify each one (name, document type, index data) and **file** it into the archive.

When the name is already taken. A folder cannot hold two things of the same name, so filing `Invoice.pdf` where an `Invoice` already sits asks you what you meant rather than refusing:

Choice	What happens
A new version of that document	The usual answer: the file is a newer revision of what is already there. The document keeps its index data and its history, and the previous version stays available.
A new document with a different name	The two are genuinely different documents that happen to share a file name. A free name is offered — `Invoice (2)` — and you can change it.

Either way you can add a **comment** saying what this file is, which becomes the version's comment. There is no "overwrite": nothing in SimplArchive replaces content in place, and the honest equivalent is a new version.

> If the name is held by a **folder** rather than a document, only the second choice is possible — a folder has no versions to add one to.

Versions. Uploading a new file to an existing document adds a **version** — the history is preserved. The **Versions** dialog lists every version; you can compare two of them or **make current** an older one. When you upload a file that already exists, SimplArchive warns you of the **duplicate**.

Give each version a **comment** saying what changed. It is the difference between a history someone can read and a list of timestamps: "Price corrected after the framework-agreement review" answers the question a reader of the list actually has, and no date can.

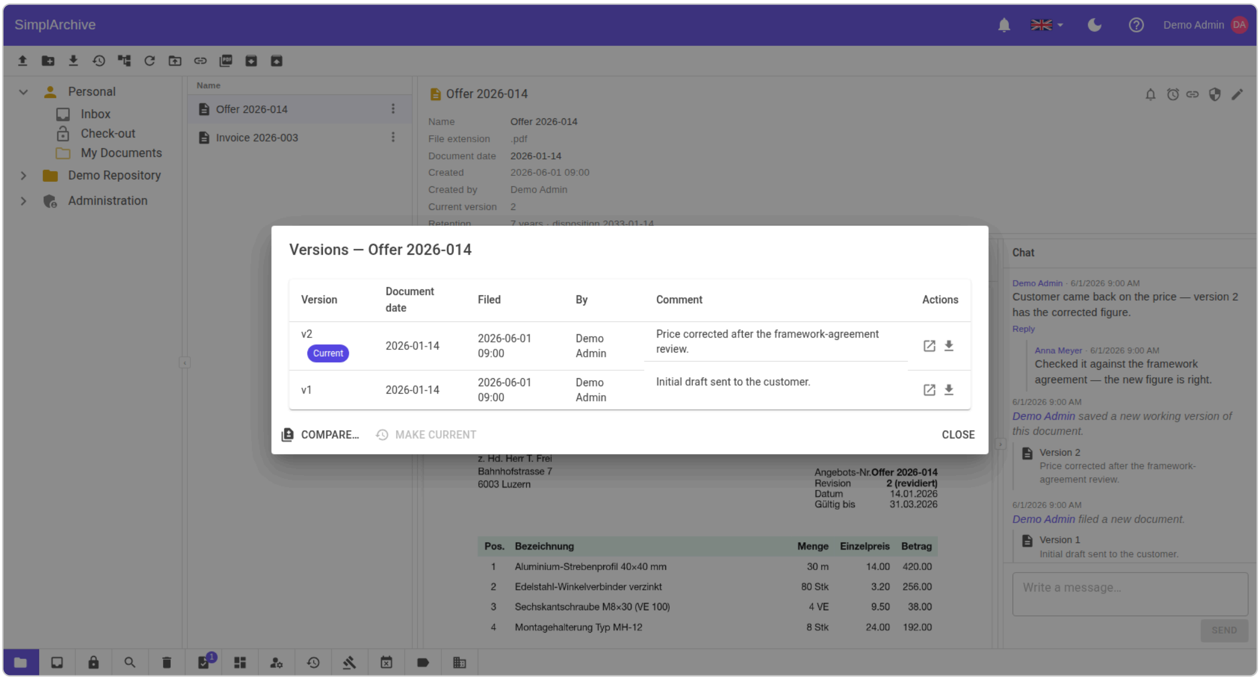

Figure 5: The **Versions** dialog: every version of the document with who saved it, when, and — the part that makes the list worth reading — the comment describing what changed.

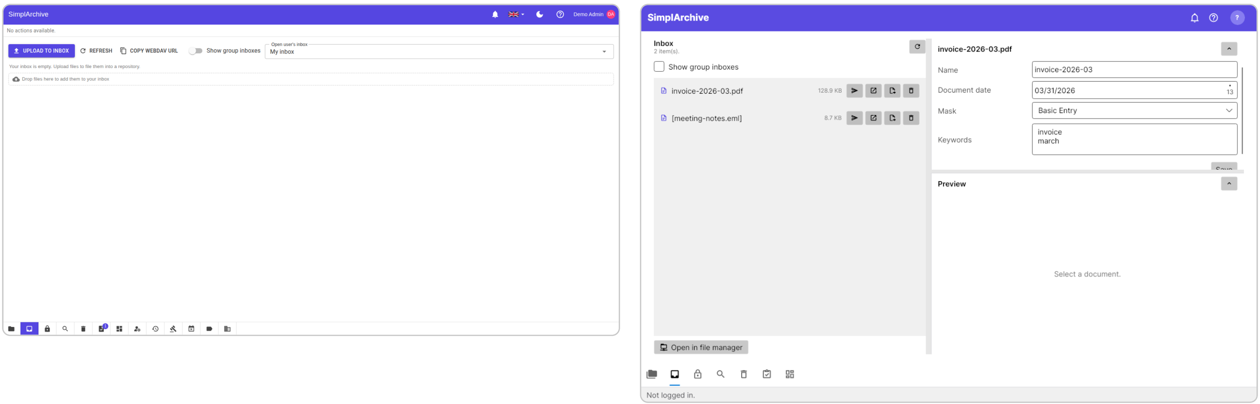

Figure 6: The Inbox: staged items waiting to be classified and filed, in the web (left) and desktop (right) clients.

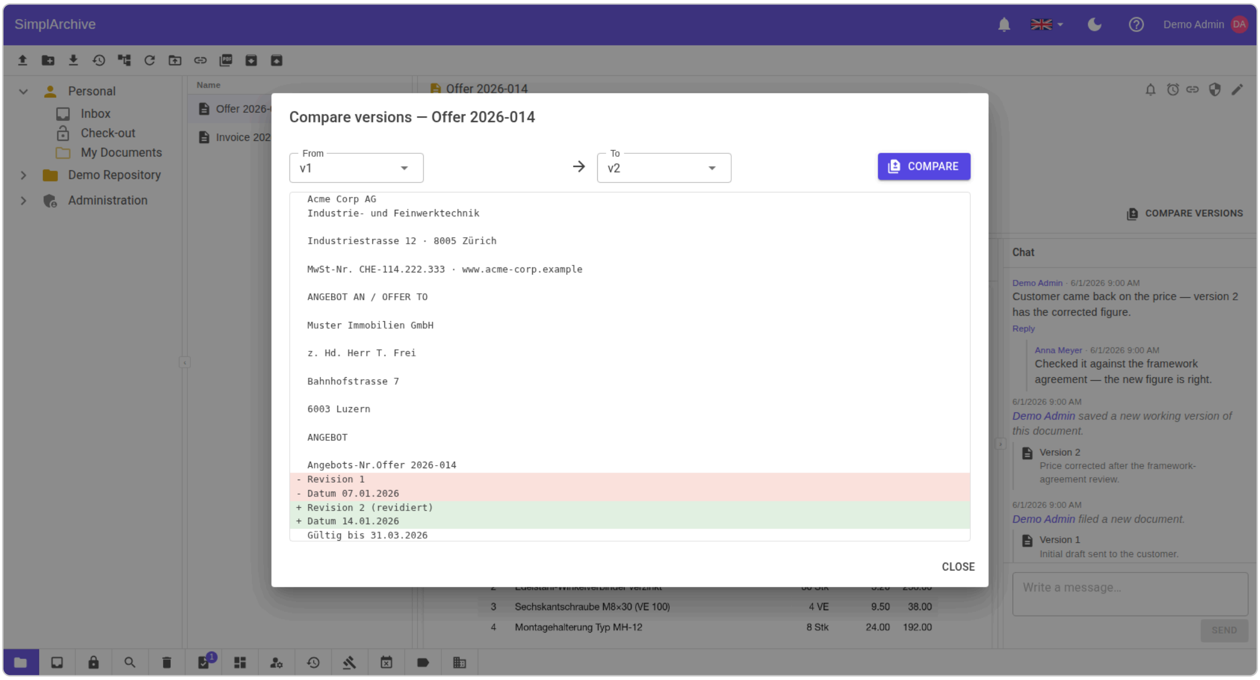

Figure 7: **Compare versions**: an inline diff of two revisions of a document — added lines marked with +, removed lines with - — so a change between versions is easy to see.

5 Organizing

Create **folders**, and **move** documents between them by drag-and-drop. A **reference** (shortcut) lets one document appear in several places without copying it. **Tags** label documents for quick grouping — your tenant can maintain a curated tag catalogue with colours. **Sensitivity labels** mark how confidential a document is. Every user also has a **personal repository** for private documents.

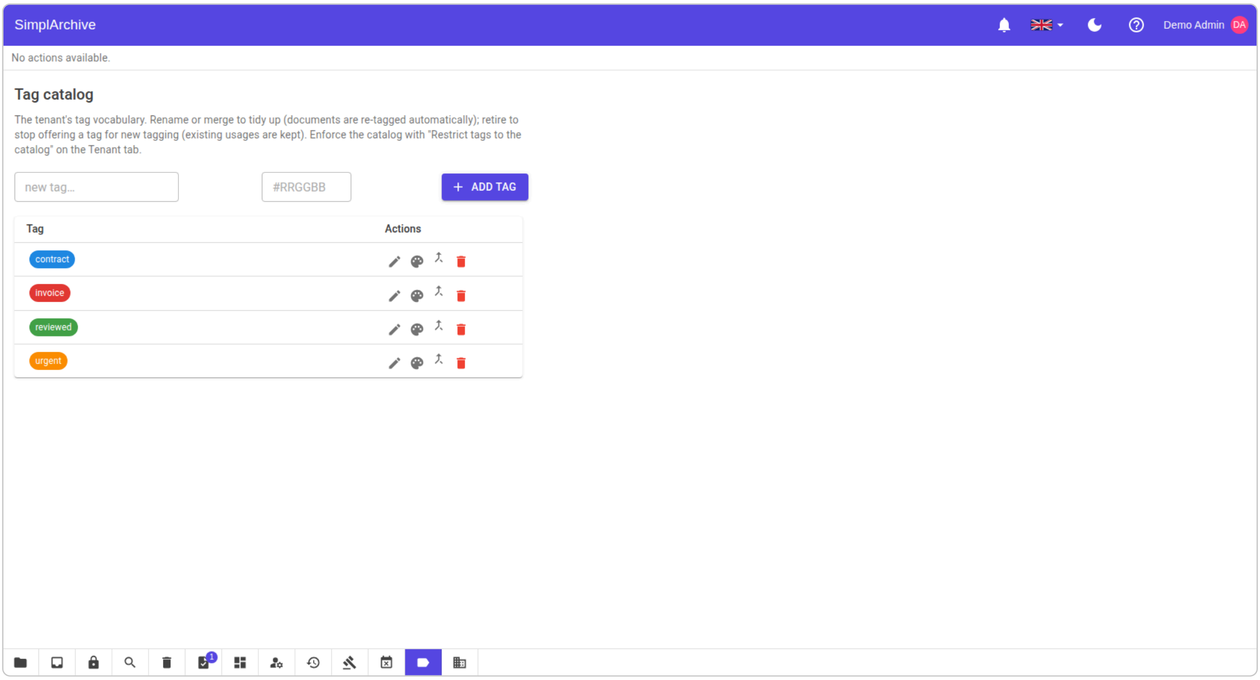

Figure 8: The tag catalogue: curated, colour-coded tags an administrator maintains for the whole tenant.

6 Working from your file manager (WebDAV)

The whole archive is reachable over **WebDAV** as a network drive — not just your personal space but the shared repositories you have permission to access, with your rights enforced on every operation. The mounted drive is called **SimplArchive** and mirrors the Repositories tree exactly: your Personal space, then the repositories you can see, and nothing else.

The **WebDAV** button does the next useful thing rather than always the same thing, and its tooltip says which. In the **desktop client**: if you have no credentials yet it opens the setup dialog; if you have credentials it mounts the drive and opens it (on Windows as a persistent drive letter, S: or the next one free); and if the drive is already mounted it goes straight there. So “show me my documents in Finder” is one click once you are set up.

It opens where you already are. There is one button per tab, and each opens **its own** folder inside the drive rather than the top of the archive:

Where you press it	What opens
Repositories ribbon	The folder selected in the tree — the drive mirrors the tree exactly, so “where I am” and “which folder on the drive” are the same place. With nothing selected, the whole archive opens.
Inbox tab, lower left	Your **Inbox** folder.
Check-out tab, lower left	Your **Check-out** folder, where working copies live.

> **If you connect to more than one SimplArchive** — a local one and a hosted one, say — your computer cannot give both drives the same name, so the second is called something like **SimplArchive-1**. The button always opens the drive belonging to the server you are signed in to, whichever name it ended up with.

The setup dialog shows the **mount URL** and your **username** (your e-mail), each with a **Copy** button, and a **Generate** button that issues an app-specific **WebDAV password** — separate from your login password and shown only once, so copy it right away. The desktop dialog also has **Open folder**, so you can go from generating credentials to a mounted drive without closing it.

The **web client** cannot mount a drive: a browser is not allowed to. Instead of leaving you with a URL and no idea what to do with it, its dialog shows the mount steps for the operating system you are on — Finder’s *Go ▸ Connect to Server* on macOS, **Map network drive** on Windows, a `davs://` address on Linux — next to the values to paste into them.

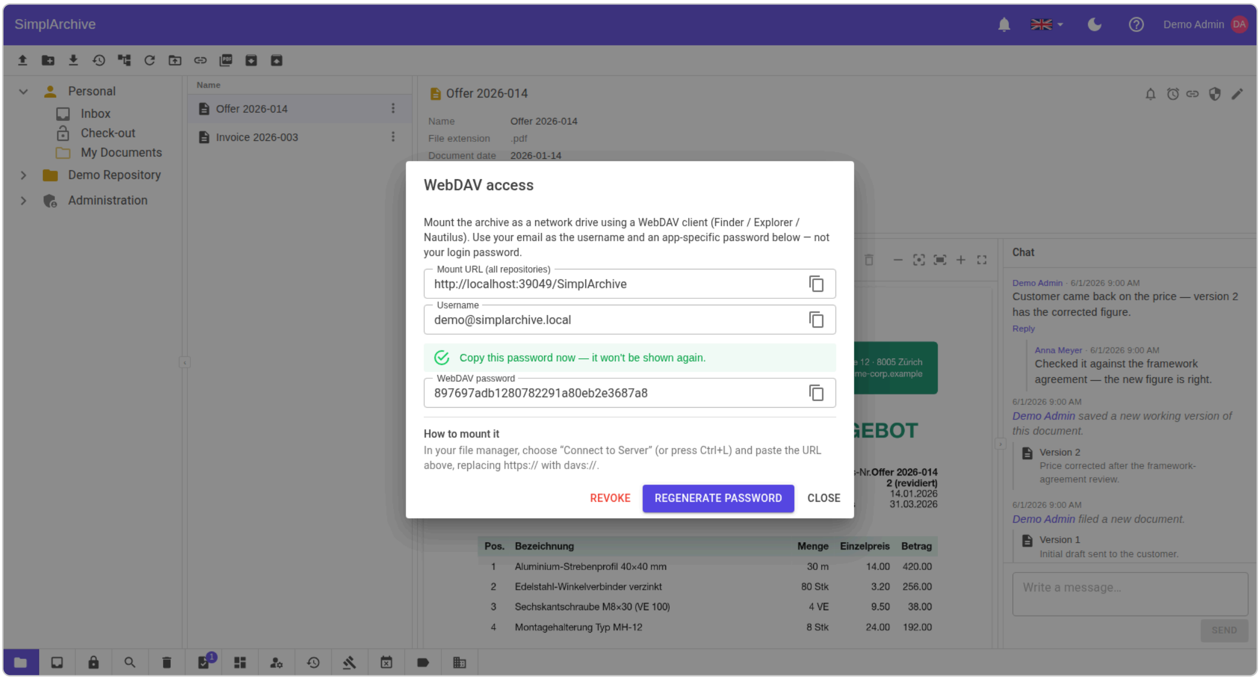

Figure 9: The web client's WebDAV dialog: the mount URL, your username and the one-shot password, each with a copy button, and the mount steps for the operating system you are using.

6.1 Editing a document in place

Open a document from the mounted drive, change it, save it — that is the whole gesture, and it works the way you would expect from any network drive.

What happens underneath is worth knowing, because it changes what other people see. Simple editors write the file straight back, and the change becomes a new version immediately. An **office suite**, however, never overwrites a file in place: it writes a hidden companion file, then a temporary copy of the new content, and finally renames that copy over the original. SimplArchive recognises that sequence and turns it into a **check-out** — the same one you get from pressing **Check out** in the app.

So after saving from your file manager:

- the document is **checked out to you**, and appears on your **Check-out** tab marked **automatic**;
- your edit is waiting there as your working copy — it is **not yet a new version**, and other people still see the previous one;
- nobody else can change the document until you are finished;
- you finish by pressing **Check in**, from either client or by saving into the mount's **Check-out** folder.

> **Saving is not the same as publishing.** The system cannot tell when you have finished editing — only you can, and **Check in** is how you say so. Until then your work is kept safely as your working copy. A check-out left untouched for a long time is released automatically by your organisation's idle rule, and you are warned before that happens.

The **automatic** marker exists so this never looks like a fault: a document you never explicitly checked out has become yours, and the tab says why, naming the program that did it.

If someone else already has the document checked out, your editor is told the file is locked and opens it read-only, rather than letting you edit for ten minutes and failing at the save. Documents you are not allowed to edit, and documents frozen by a legal hold, behave in the mount exactly as they do in the app: they refuse.

> **A warning from your own software is not a fault in ours.** Some commercial vendors treat a WebDAV connection to a site that is not on their own allow-list as suspicious, or refuse it outright. That is a policy

> decision in the respective vendors' software, not a limitation of SimplArchive — the same mount that one program declines will typically work in another on the same machine.

7 Metadata & classification

Each document has a **mask** (document type) that defines its **index fields** — typed metadata such as an invoice number or a date. Open the **detail** pane's edit toggle to fill them in. A document also carries a **document date** and one or more **OCR languages** used to make scans searchable.

> Index fields are validated by the mask — a field marked required must be filled, and format/range rules are enforced when you save. Well-known masks (Folder, Basic Entry, e-Mail) exist in every tenant; administrators can add more.

8 Search

The **Search** tab runs a full-text search across document **content**, **names**, and **index-field** values, ranked by relevance, with hits highlighted on the preview — so a distinctive word buried in a document's text (a product name on an invoice, say) finds exactly that document. **Refinement filters** and **facets** narrow the results — by document type, date, sensitivity, and more — and you can **save** a search to re-run or share it later.

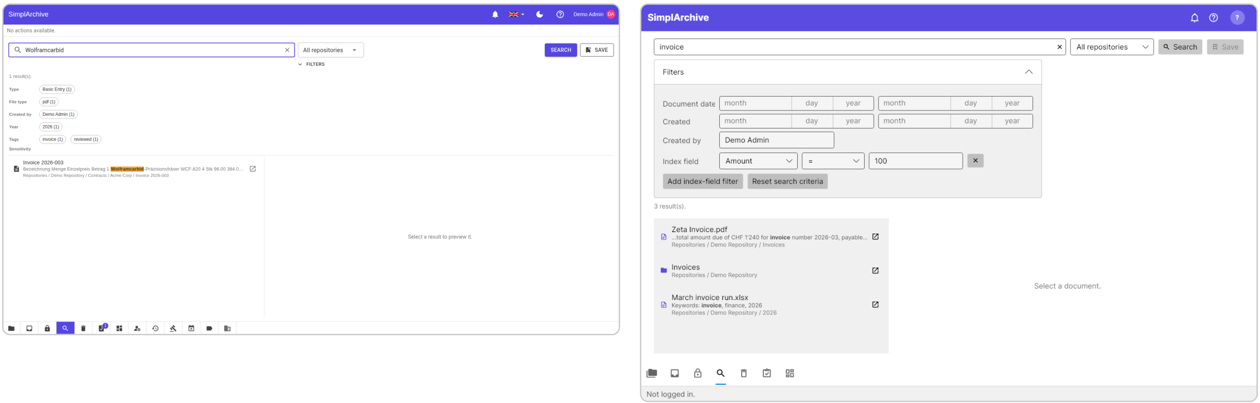

Figure 10: Full-text search with refinement filters and facets, in the web (left) and desktop (right) clients.

Parts of words. Search matches whole words first, which is what keeps the most relevant document at the top. If that finds nothing, the search is retried looking for your text **inside** words — so `montage` finds a document that only ever says `Montagehalterung`, and `sechskant` finds the longer compound containing it. This matters most in German, where one word does the work of several. The second attempt is slower and its ranking is flatter, so it only runs when the first found nothing at all.

9 Collaboration

Documents are collaborative: post **comments** in a feed, attach **annotations** (sticky notes, highlights, and shapes) onto the preview, and **follow** a document or folder to be **notified** of activity. Set yourself a **reminder**, and track everything assigned to you on the **My work** dashboard. To edit a document exclusively, **check it out** — others see it is locked — then **check in** your changes as a new version.

The chat thread. Every document has its own thread, shown beside the preview. Use it for the conversation about the document — a question about a figure, a note that a revision is on its way — so that discussion stays with the document instead of in someone's mailbox. Replies nest under the message they answer, and the thread also records what happened to the document: a new version, a filing, and other activity appear in the same timeline, so reading it tells you both what people said and what changed.

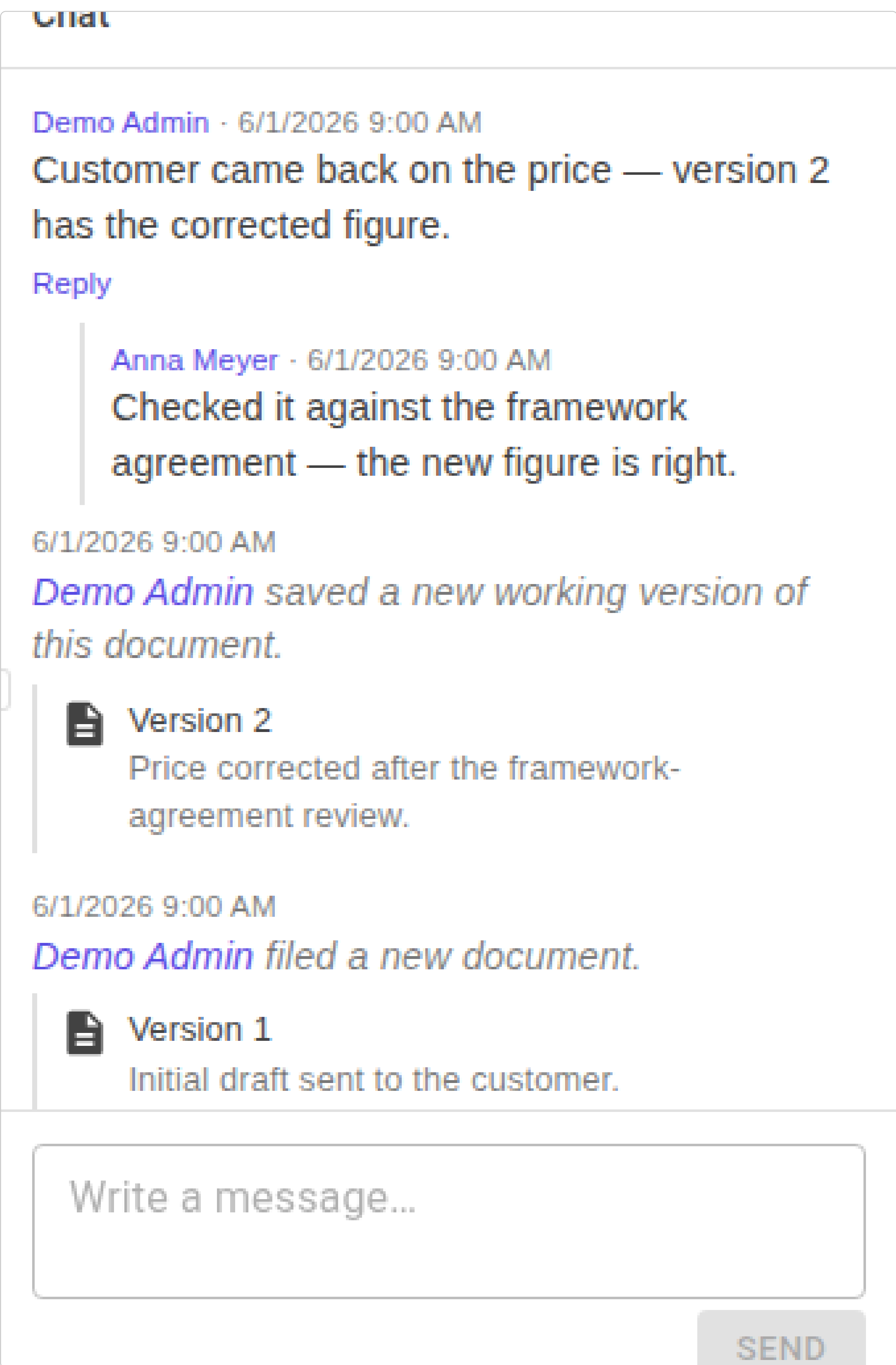

Figure 11: The chat pane on a document: a threaded conversation interleaved with the document's own activity — here a question and its reply, followed by the two versions as they were saved.

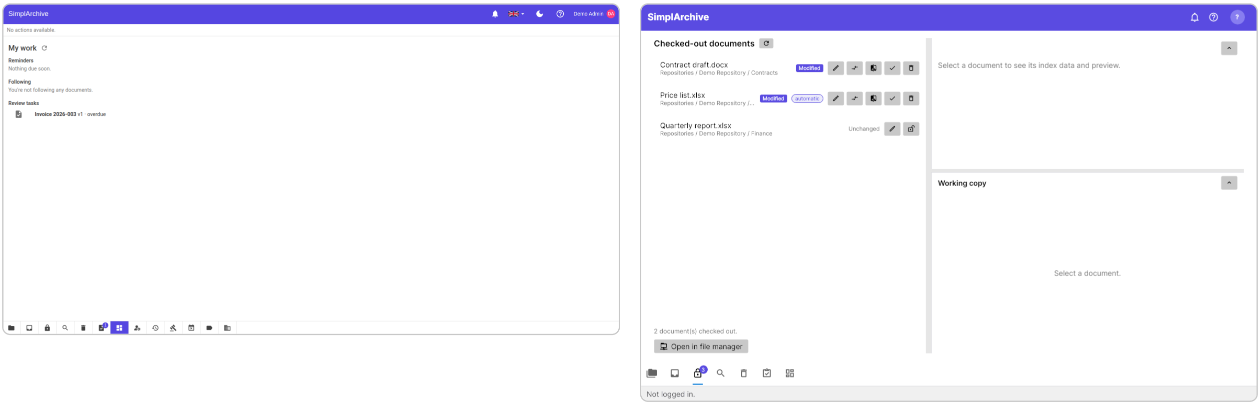

Figure 12: Left: the **My work** dashboard. Right: the **Check-out** tab listing documents locked for exclusive editing — here one edited (*Modified*) and one untouched (*Unchanged*).

Seeing your edit before you commit it. The **Check-out** tab shows what you are **about to check in**, not what is already archived. Select a document you hold and the pane beside the list shows its index data and a preview of your **working copy** — the file as you have edited it. That is the version the **Check in** action will create, so you can look at it before committing, without leaving the tab to go and find the archived copy (which would show you the one thing that is certainly not your edit).

A document you have edited is marked **Modified**, and only those offer the actions that make sense for an edit:

Action	What it does
Compare	An inline, side-by-side view of what changed between the archived version and your working copy.
Beyond Compare	Opens the same two files in Beyond Compare, if you use it — a desktop-only convenience, since a browser is not allowed to launch another application. Not affiliated with SimplArchive; the button points you to the vendor if you do not have it.
Check in	Files your working copy as a new version and releases the lock.
Discard	Throws the working copy away and releases the lock, leaving the archived version untouched.

> If you have not saved anything to your working copy yet, the preview stays empty rather than showing the archived version. There is genuinely nothing to preview, and showing the archived file there would be answering a different question.

10 Sharing outside SimplArchive

Everything above assumes the other person has an account. An **external link** is for when they do not: a plain URL that opens one document, for anyone who has it, with no sign-in. Use it for the customer who needs the signed contract or the auditor who needs one invoice — not as a general-purpose way to move documents around.

Creating one. Select the document and open **External links…** from the detail pane. Choose when it should expire and how many times it may be opened, then create it.

> **The URL is shown once, at creation, and never again.** Copy it before you close the dialog. It appears in no list afterwards — deliberately, because a list is read far more widely, and far more casually, than the moment you deliberately created something.

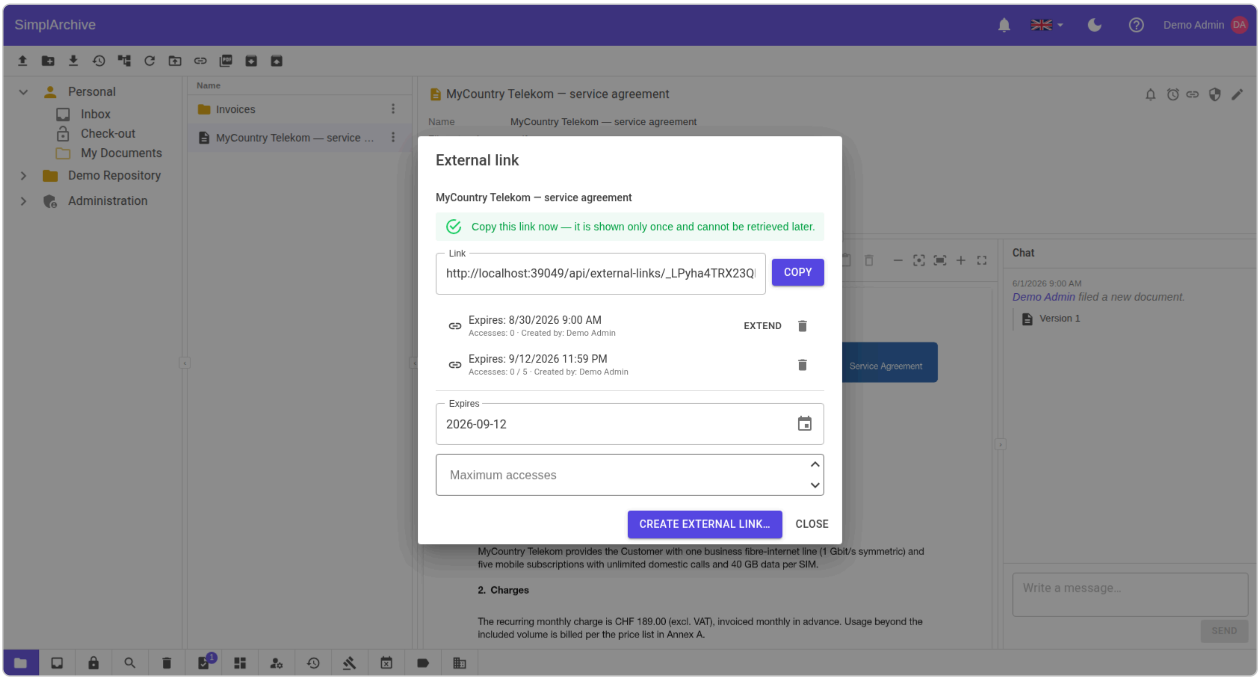

Figure 13: Creating an external link. The URL is revealed once, here, and cannot be retrieved later.

Managing what you have shared. My external links on the ribbon lists your live links: which document, when it expires, how many times it has been opened. From a row you can jump to the document, review a link's details, or **revoke** it. An administrator sees everyone's, filtered by user or group.

A link near its expiry can be **extended** — but only within 30 days of lapsing, by at most 90 days, and measured from today rather than added to whatever time remains. So extending is a deliberate renewal, not a way to accumulate an indefinite link.

> **Revoking does not delete the row.** It stamps it revoked and leaves the record standing — who shared what, with effect from when. After a link has leaked, that record is exactly what the investigation needs, and it would be gone if revoking tidied it away.

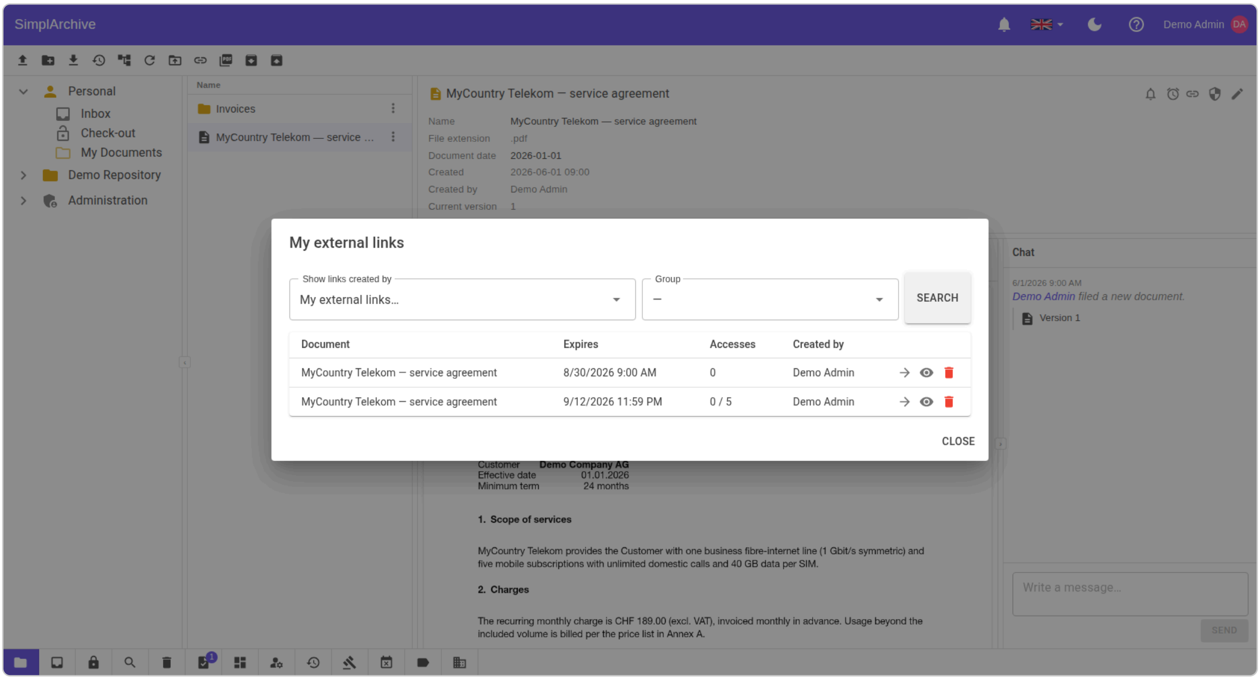

Figure 14: **My external links** — every live link you have shared, with go-to, details and revoke on each row.

What the recipient sees. A single page with the document's name, a picture of its first page, and buttons to open or download it — with the number of pages marked on the picture when there is more than one, so they know what they are about to open. Nothing else: no tree, no navigation, no route to any other document.

The picture is drawn when you create the link, not when the recipient opens it, so there is nothing to wait for. A document with no picture to draw — an archive, a binary — simply shows its name and the buttons.

An unknown, expired, exhausted or revoked link all produce the **same** response. That is deliberate — telling a stranger which of those they hit would confirm a real link exists and hint at how to reach a usable one.

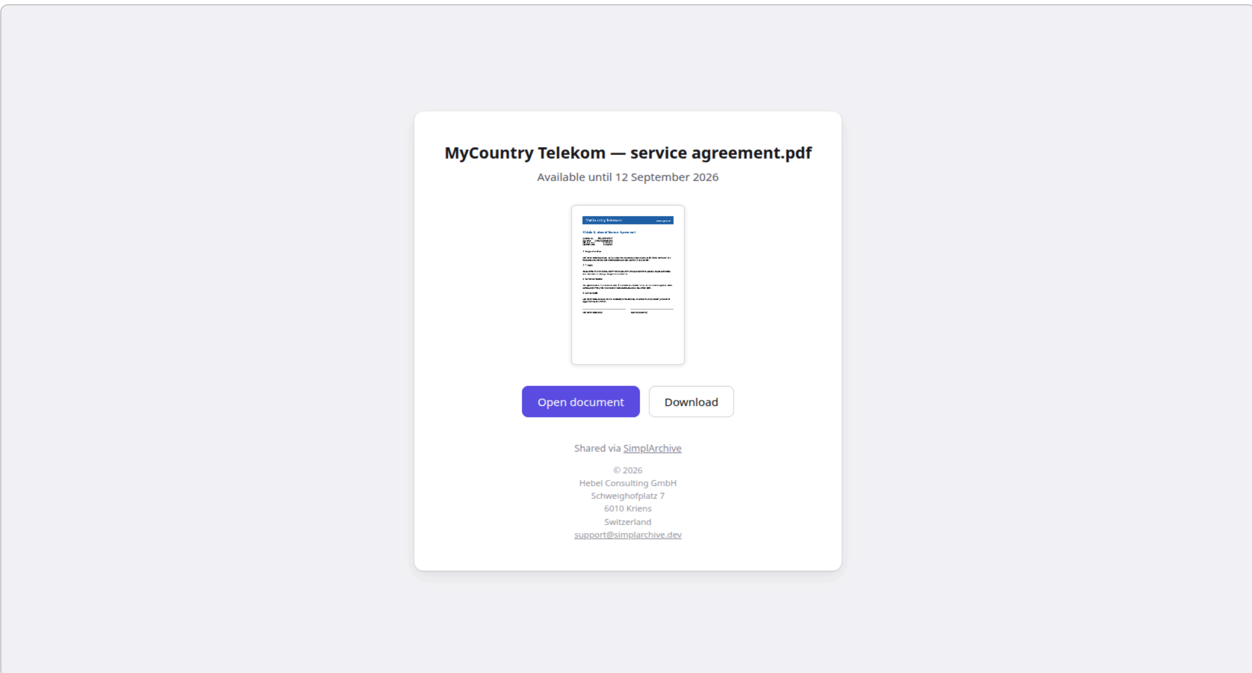

Figure 15: The recipient's view: the document's name and a picture of its first page. This one is a single page, so it carries no page-count marker. No account, one document, nothing else reachable from it.

10.1 The controls an administrator holds

Sharing outward is the one action that leaves the system, so it is gated twice and can be stopped in one move.

- **Two gates on creating a link.** The tenant-wide **Allow external links** switch must be on, and the individual needs the **Create external link** right, granted per user or group from **Users & groups**. Either alone is enough to prevent sharing; both must be present to allow it. A service account can never create one — only a person shares, so there is always someone accountable for a link's existence.
- **The kill switch.** Turning **Allow external links** off is checked when a link is **opened**, not only when one is created — so it stops every link already out in the world, not merely future ones. This is the control to reach for when something has leaked, and it is worth knowing about before you need it.
- **The caps you set. Maximum link lifetime** (default 180 days) and **default access count** (default 5) are the rails everyone else shares within. Tighten them to your own policy rather than relying on people choosing well.

11 Workflow & records

Approval workflow. Submit a document for review and it moves through a fixed state machine — Draft ⟶ In Review ⟶ Approved / Rejected ⟶ Released. Reviewers act on their **Tasks** tab reviews can be reassigned, and overdue reviews escalate.

Records management. A **legal hold** freezes documents so they cannot be changed or deleted. **Retention** policies dispose of documents once their retention period ends (with review before disposition, if required). Deleted documents rest in the **Recycle bin**, from which an administrator can restore them or purge them permanently.

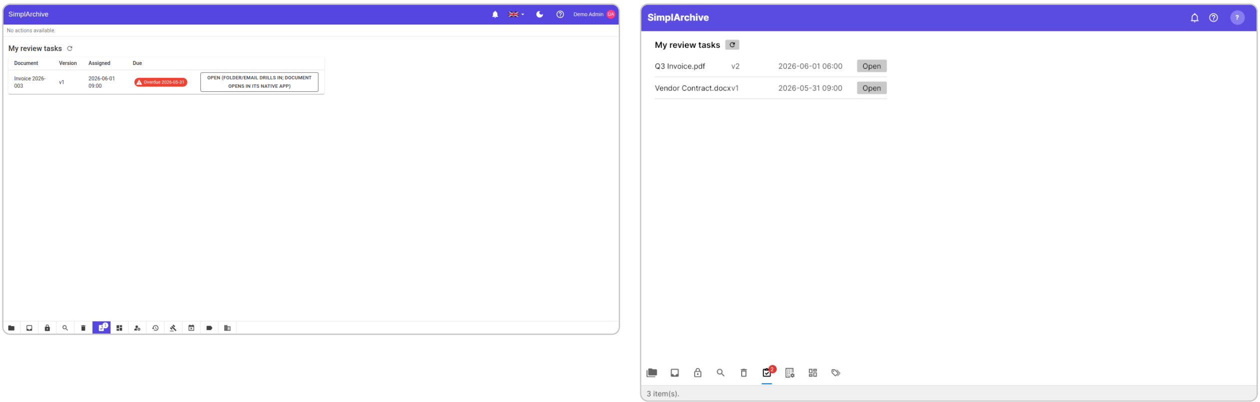

Figure 16: The Tasks tab — a reviewer's approval queue — in the web (left) and desktop (right) clients.

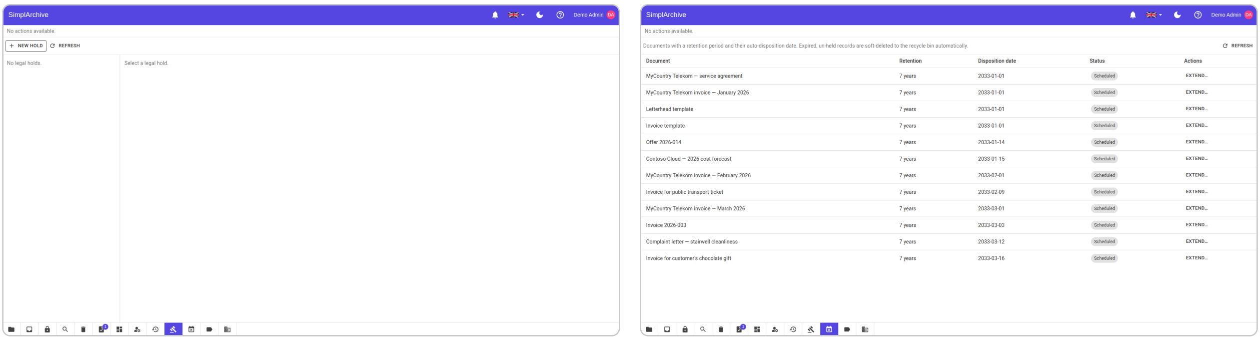

Figure 17: Records management: **legal holds** (left) freeze documents; **retention** (right) governs disposition.

12 Administration & account

Administrators manage **users & groups** and the **rights** granted to them, configure **tenant** settings, and review the tamper-evident **audit trail** of every security-relevant action. They also curate catalogues (sensitivity labels, tags), set the **storage quota**, and run **import / export**. Every user manages their own **account security** — password, multi-factor authentication (authenticator app or passkeys), and profile photo.

Your own account lives behind **Edit profile…** in the avatar menu (top right in both clients). It shows which account you are signed in as, the photo you currently have with a crop to replace it, and a button through to changing your password. Two-factor authentication, passkeys and the WebDAV password stay as their own entries in that menu, since each is a separate credential rather than part of your profile.

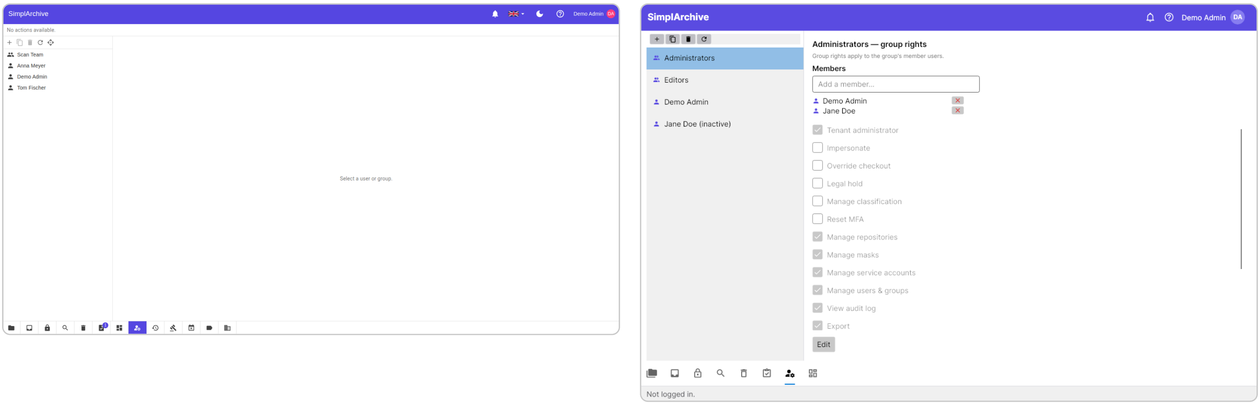

Figure 18: Users & groups administration in the web (left) and desktop (right) clients.

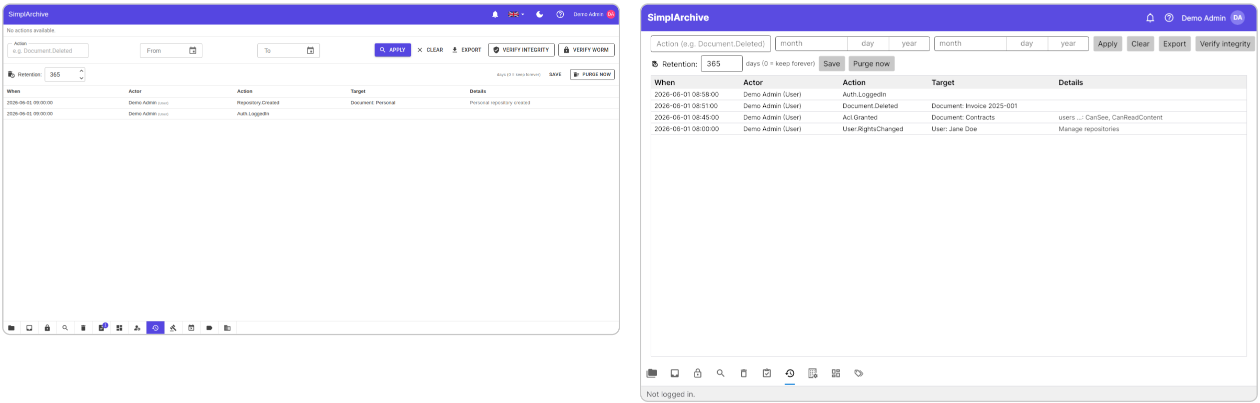

Figure 19: The audit trail — an append-only, hash-chained log — in the web (left) and desktop (right) clients.

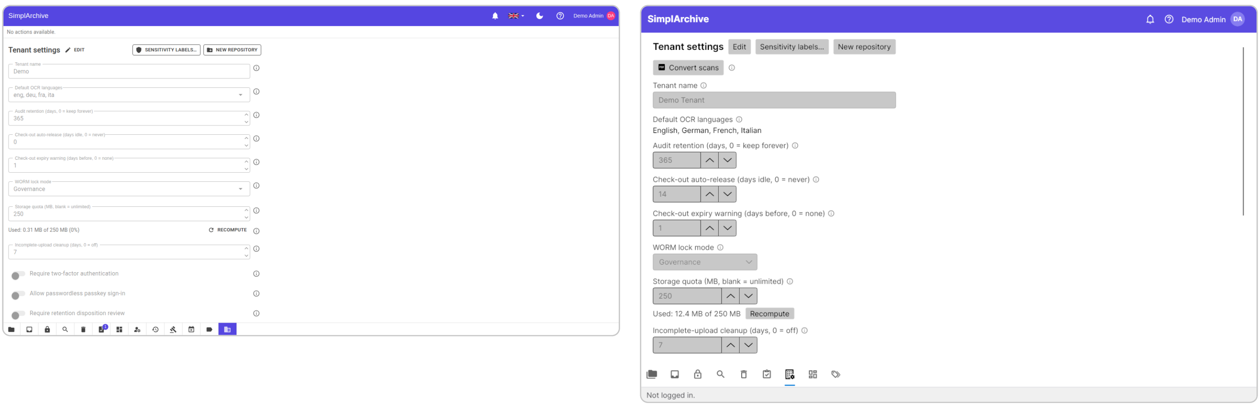

Figure 20: Tenant settings in the web (left) and desktop (right) clients.

The desktop client can connect to **several servers** its server manager stores a profile (name + address) for each. A server is not a tenant: one SimplArchive installation hosts many tenants, and which tenant you belong to follows from the account you sign in with.

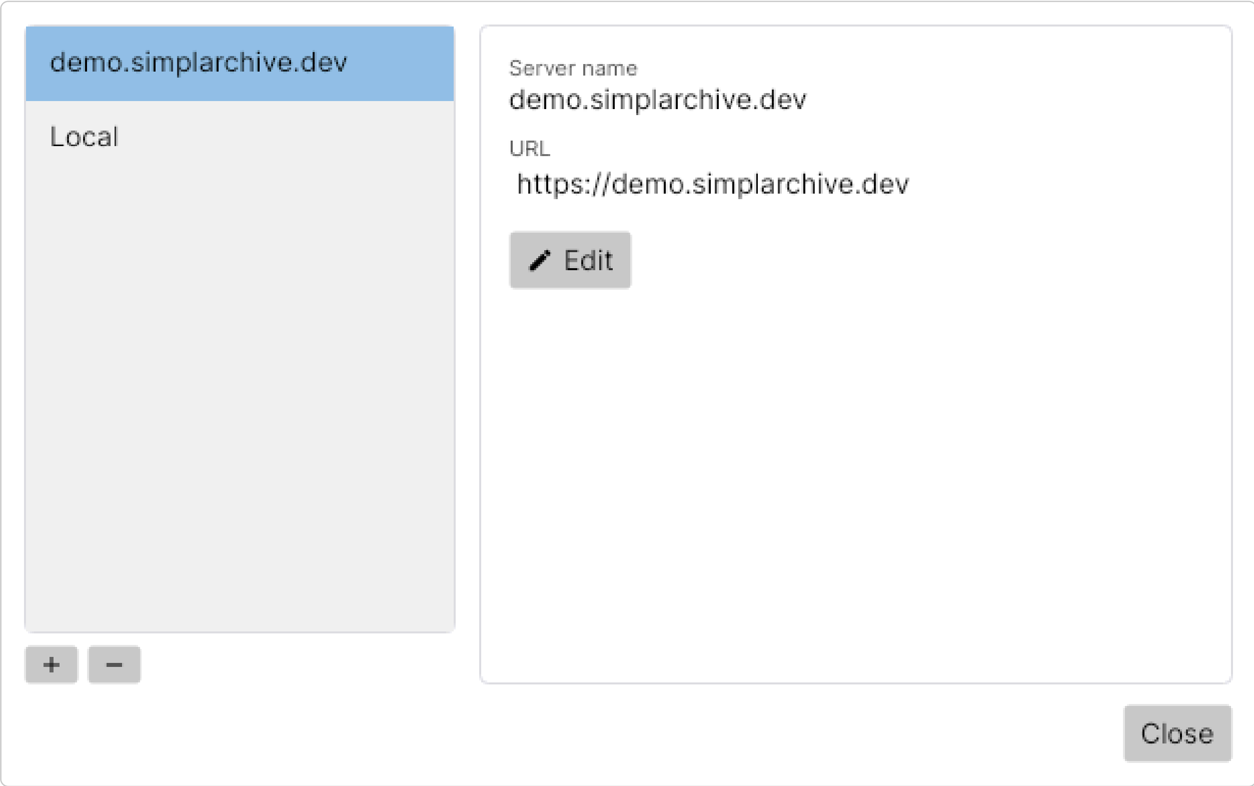

Figure 21: The desktop server manager: connection profiles for several SimplArchive servers.

13 Appendix — glossary & links

> **Repository** — a root folder (a document with no parent). **Mask** — a document type / set of index fields. **ACL** — per-document access-control list. **Version** — an immutable snapshot of a document's file. **Legal hold** — a freeze that blocks change/deletion. **Retention** — a policy that disposes of documents after a period.

Further reading:

- The live API description — the OpenAPI document at `/openapi/v1.json`.
- Desktop-client downloads — the download area at `/download`.

This manual's screenshots are regenerated from the running application on every release, so they never fall out of date.

14 Index

Terms are indexed where the manual explains them, not at every mention — the page listed is the one worth turning to.